LEADERSHIP TRANSITIONS IN UNIVERSITIES

Arriving, Surviving and Thriving at the Top

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7 Senior leadership teams

More than you

Like all jobs, you've got to assess the qualities of the senior team – who are the leaders and who are the followers, who are the agitators and who are the pacifists and who's got their agenda and who's a team player. It's about helping others, helping the team reach a team consensus rather than leading the team to come round to your answer . . . and I think there are lots of small little milestones. You can't ever say that there is one pivotal moment where they were never following you at 09:00 and at 10:00 they were. It's just a small little series of seemingly tiny little events and processes which constitute the development of a team with trust and confidence.

Introduction

'Leadership is a team sport' is an often-repeated assertion. One of the early transition challenges that most heads of universities (HoUs) face therefore unsurprisingly relates to their 'top team'. In Chapter 5, we discussed Lencioni's distinction between reward-centred and responsibility-centred leadership as motives for becoming a leader at the top. Lencioni[1] identified five common omissions associated with those who believe leadership is a reward. All five are directly related to team working. They include: paying lip service to building the executive team, managing direct reports (and ensuring they manage their team members), having difficult and uncomfortable conversations with direct reports, running great team meetings and communicating constantly and repetitively as the chief reminding officer (CRO). In addition, in Chapter 6, we highlighted a series of questions posed by Hsieh and Bear[2] associated with CEO transitions. Adding to these, they suggest some further questions that you might consider about your team:

> *Beyond probing for each person's competence, aspiration, credibility, and the like, a new leader must assess the personal impact each member has on the team and on the rest of the organisation. Is she a positive influence on the people she works with? Is his concern for self-interest in balance with his concern for the collective good? Does she nourish or merely exploit her peers and subordinates? Do his actions, not just his words, uphold the values I hold dear? Is she a good role model for the kind of leadership this company needs?*

This chapter builds on corporate sector experience by exploring the types of analyses that a new HoU may wish to undertake when thinking about their senior team. It also uncovers some of the common challenges that you will likely experience, where you will need to focus your attention to create a high-performing team and how to recognise when team working is not the appropriate solution to a challenge.

Questions about the senior team

What common questions arise when people reflect on the senior team in a university context, and how might you address these? Consider the following example questions:

- What and whom have I inherited? What does the team do? Does it work? Is it a team?
- How do I assess how well the team operates? (You will have more insight if you have stepped up from within the team, but now the rules have changed.)
- Do I change the team, and if so, in what ways? When is the best time to do so?
- Do I create a large inclusive team, and if so, how large? Do I have an inner team within a broader body or a small 'top team'?
- Do I appoint a deputy? If so, what do I need from this person?
- Do I take time to consult widely or seize the moment and take quick pre-emptive action?
- Do I appoint from within or do I go out to the wider market-place?
- In whom can I confide to talk through my emerging ideas?

The pressure on a new HoU 'to get it right' is high. All leaders will have had experience of either observing, or being part of, a dysfunctional top team. You might have encountered the 'team' as a group of individuals with separate portfolios, sharing nothing except a lack of interest in each other's respective agendas. Or you might have come across the highly competitive, passive-aggressive team of rivals who find the time they spend together of little real value or interest. To add to the pressures on you, from appointment, you will have been advised from many quarters about the shortcomings and limitations of one or several members of the team (and, more frequently than one might expect, by members of that team).

Before exploring these issues, let's return to some basic foundations. What do we understand by the term *team*? How does it manifest itself at the top in a university context? How do you create that elusive entity, the high-performing team? Consider the following metaphor:

- What sort of sporting team (or not) do you wish to create?
- What type of sporting team do you want to develop?
- What kind of leadership do you need to provide for this sporting team to succeed?

Many aspects of the ideas presented in this chapter build on earlier work in *The Composition, Challenges and Changes in the Top Team Structures of UK Higher Education Institutions*, by Kennie and Woodfield (2008).[3]

Team metaphors

The sporting team metaphor can be a useful or less useful way of identifying the nature of the team you wish to create. Charles Handy captured his perception of teams in the business world by using the metaphor of a rowing eight. He described a typical British team as follows:

> *Eight people going backwards as fast as they can, without talking to each other and steered by the only person who can't row.*

Is this an amusing and insightful viewpoint? He also suggested, however, that the winning high-performing rowing eight also shares

> *total confidence in each other, a shared commitment, a passion for the same goal, and total confidence in the one person who can't row.*

The power of the sporting team metaphor was also conveyed in the following quote from the earlier research on top teams in higher education.[4] This female respondent used the metaphor of a football team, describing her experience of joining the team:

> *I saw myself playing in midfield, very energetic, passing the ball to others, supporting the strikers upfront, occasionally getting close to scoring myself. Then I realised I was playing the wrong game.*

Instead, she found herself among a group of athletes:

> *One trying to jump higher and higher, one running around faster and faster, and one seeking to throw a spear further and further (while seeking to avoid the person running around).*

The team they were joining was one of high-performing individuals – more of a Team GB Olympic squad than the Premier League team – to use UK sporting terminology.

A sporting metaphor takes us only so far. The reality of a top team, for some respondents, was captured in another interview from the same research project:

> *We call it, well, it depends who you talk to, but I mean – team? We're not a team, no, we're not a team, and we're not a committee either. I'd say we're a kind of loose group of individuals who meet together on a regular basis. I mean – so it's a kind of working group if you like. . . . We're not* ***just*** *a loose*

> *group of people, but we are a working group, and a reasonably effective working group that comes together regularly.*
>
> (our emphasis, in boldface)

Teams and team working

Although easy to recognise one when you see it, defining a team can be tricky. Katzenbach and Smith[5] offer one insight in their succinct definition of a team:

> *A (real team) is a small number of people with complementary skills who are committed to a common purpose, agreed performance goals and an approach for which they hold themselves mutually accountable.*[6]

This is the classic interdependent form of team. It can be thought of as complementary to the concept of the extradependent team (addressed later).

The mutual accountability challenge is interesting. In one university, this definition was met with incredulity by one member of a senior team:

> *I have no idea what you mean. Of course we are all collectively accountable.*

But *mutual* and *collective* accountabilities, although apparently similar, are different. The latter implies a degree of collective ownership over a shared agenda. The former descriptor adds a dimension by recognising the significance of interdependence between activities and the importance of supporting and challenging each other, even in areas where those involved may not be the subject or portfolio expert.

'Mutual accountability' could, understandably, be a novel concept in higher education. The route to a senior role is heavily influenced by individual success, as a researcher, through driving financial performance or through success in a specialist area (as a dean or a director). Although team performance mattered in these earlier roles, it was typically within a domain for which you had full responsibility and considerable expertise. After earlier success in these roles, it may not be too surprising that becoming a fully fledged team player with mutual accountability does not come easily. Such accountability can be fostered by carefully considering the portfolios of individuals, as one of our interviewees described:

> *In my team, each person's portfolio is 'grey'. This causes problems for individuals, but it's much better from the VC's perspective as the team must work together.*

A matrix approach, which encourages working on common goals, was emphasised by another of our interviewees:

> *I do believe in recognising talent and in some senses, structures are artificial, people are real. So . . . you start off with what you think is right for*

> *the organisation and what you are about and you know, structures need to be clear so that people understand who is doing what. Particularly in large organisations like this, although there is always a degree of matrix isn't there, of people working across portfolios and working on common goals together. . . . Nobody does it all on their own, you know, having a great team around you is hugely important and having a team that has different strengths. So, I don't really want the structural arrangements to get in the way too much.*

A third interviewee emphasised creating a team-based culture where individuals gained recognition from the HoU, by working together:

> *My predecessor had a very particular way of running his senior team, and it took me 18 months to unpick that, because, what I like is a team that are not in competition with each other, who can work together and help solve other peoples' issues if they have them or they say, 'Oh, I'll come and help you out with this', or 'why don't we try such and such', and it took them a long time to realise that I was serious about that and that if someone made a mistake, I'd tell them what I thought but wouldn't hold it against them.*

To address the mutual accountability challenge, you might consider two further approaches. The first can help define *what* the team is mutually accountable for, and the second can clarify *how* to model mutual accountability.

First, invite your top team members to summarise their strategic objectives and priorities for the next 12 months and their linkage to the university's strategic agenda. Importantly, ask them to identify with whom they need to work to deliver these objectives. Then, ask team members to circulate their summary in advance of a session to reflect on the findings. This can help team members stand in each other's shoes (while also reducing any sense of stepping on each other's toes).

For the *how* aspect of mutual accountability, you might reflect on your early period in office and note examples of who does (or who doesn't) exemplify the following aspects of mutual accountability in their ways of working:

- *Vision*: Actively promoting the institutional ambition and vision – being a real advocate of the university's strategy
- *Valuing (though their behaviours)*: Role modelling and reinforcing the values and behaviours (if defined) that are currently part of our strategy
- *Validating (each other)*: Demonstrating support for each other's agendas when engaging and communicating with the university community
- *Vocalising*: Providing a coherent and consistent voice about the team's agenda

Recent research in a study titled *Failure at the Top: How Power Undermines Collaborative Performance*[7] offers insights into the impact of power on performance. Researchers Hildreth and Anderson conclude that high-power individuals are more effective when working on some tasks – those that required less coordination. They were more creative and persisted longer on a difficult task than other groups did.

However, the researchers found in multiple studies that when high-power individuals were required to work together on difficult issues demanding high levels of coordination, they performed worse than groups of lower-power teams. The possession and experience of power which can make some individuals more capable than others on individual tasks appears also to undermine their ability to get along and work with others on collaborative tasks.

To address these potential outcomes, Hildreth and Anderson emphasised two forms of group processes. First, groups whose members express positive sentiments towards each other tend to perform better. Positive interactions built trust and communication and motivated members to contribute more to the group. Groups of high-power individuals appeared less likely to engage in positive interactions with each other. High-power individuals' propensity to interrupt more often and speak out of turn, ignore others' perspectives and devalue others' contributions led to these groups of individuals' being less likely to positively reinforce each other's ideas, thereby hampering collaboration, cohesion and performance.

A second approach is called for in circumstances where high levels of status conflict are experienced by groups of high-power individuals. In these cases, the authors suggest a group process that requires increased mutual recognition and voicing of opinions, so as to reduce the potential for status threat and conflict to arise. They also suggest implementing more-formal information-sharing strategies so that members of these groups become cognisant of all the relevant information before making decisions, thus mitigating the risk that relevant information is not shared. Structuring meeting time and formalising decision processes may also help these groups focus on the task at hand rather than on other matters.

What insights does this work offer for higher education top team leaders?

- First is the obvious parallel of top teams' comprising high-power individuals.
- Second is the importance of a focus on group processes. According to our experience, unless some mediation takes place by the leader, the detrimental impact of high-power individuals on team performance can be considerable. We encourage HoUs not to wait too long before intervening where such conditions emerge.
- Third is the importance of encouraging the expression of positive sentiments between team members. As team leader, role modelling can be a helpful starting point. If the only sentiments that your team members hear in public are largely critical, then others will be unlikely publicly to offer supportive comments about the work of other team members.

- Finally, finding group processes (as outlined earlier) that encourage and enable effective decision-making – particularly cases which demand a high level of cabinet responsibility – is important. We have seen real value from the team's agreeing on a set of principles and protocols to help guide them when making challenging decisions. By itself, this doesn't stop an overly dominant individual's negatively influencing the final decision, but it can help.

When power dynamics are apparent, the question of appropriate timing of interventions arises. The experience of one of our interviewees provides one response:

> *I think the people who come in and throw out a team . . . for me, I just couldn't do it. You know, there might be circumstances where it's necessary, but you lose all that institutional knowledge and you don't have it. You just don't have it. So, I'm a great believer in a bit of grit in the oyster. I think you mustn't have group thinking, you have to have people who've got different views. At times, it's frustrating, but it is always the best way to take decisions. You get advice that is contradictory and that helps you weigh up the options. So, I still have people in my team who go back to the very early days of this institution and I have people whom I've appointed.*

Is it merely a matter of personal values or a preference for a particular leadership style? Can and do HoUs respond differently if the circumstances they inherit demand different actions? One of our interviewees with experience as an HoU at two universities described some differences:

> *In* [my first university] *I spoke to the senior team and actually felt I don't want to make any changes here. I just want to reallocate. I think [my predecessor] had appointed a really cohesive team, people who knew what they were doing, were high quality and all got on. . . .* [At the second university,] *I successfully replaced everybody on the whole team or brought in people who weren't in it before. So, yes, I've done an almost complete renewal, I would say.*

Team working

Leading a high-performing senior leadership team involves a series of delicate balancing acts. At least three exist:

1. How do you decide on what, individually and collectively, you need to pay attention to and what the areas of mutual accountability are?
2. How do you guide and shape the process of decision-making for the team, balancing approaches across different types of decisions?
3. How do you balance a focus on not only *what* you need to do as a team but also *how* you operate as a team?

The what

What the team needs to pay attention to involves focusing on individual and collective priorities. Start by asking each team member to share, with their colleagues, the priorities that you as HoU have agreed on with each team member. This process alone can prove enlightening and valuable as you move on to the team-based priorities for action.

One framework to guide you with the *what* can be informed by Figure 7.1. This highlights eight zones to which a senior team should pay attention. Each zone offers a different perspective on potential priorities. Inviting each team member to consider these and then consolidate their collective views can offer some helpful insight into what the team members believe are their priorities for action.

The eight zones include a focus on the following characteristics:

- *Strategy oriented* – reviewing, revising or completely revisiting the current strategy
- *Exploring* – relationship building, focusing on developing a limited number of deep and substantive partnerships to support several facets
    - Research
    - Teaching and learning
    - Knowledge exchange
    - Civic/community links
    - Global engagement
- *Engaging* – engaging with industry/community/funding partners to respond to educational and research needs or engaging with others to develop coalitions and alliances to influence issues of societal importance

Figure 7.1 Framework to guide the *what*

- *Business innovating* – consolidating academic and business activities by building new programmes; marketing services and products to satisfy unmet or unrecognised needs; and exercising a willingness to invest, be disruptive and take calculated risks
- *Developing* – focusing on developing a range of capabilities and skills, such as those technical (digital), academic or professional in nature, to meet the new needs of students and to meet leadership skills and capabilities in order to shape the culture required to deliver the university strategy
- *Regulating* – focusing on improving the efficiency and consistency of internal processes and meeting the standards set by regulatory bodies, by paying attention to capturing accurate data used by regulators and rankings agencies
- *Trouble shooting* – being responsive to emerging challenges by recognising the importance of effective and efficient systems and the importance of stopping activities that are no longer financially viable
- *Team building* – emphasising building effective cross-university teams that will deliver the strategic priorities and developing effective working practices among the senior leadership and between it and the governing board

In addition, asking team members to assess what they believe should be the highest priorities for the senior team over the forthcoming 6–12 months (by ranking the top three of the eight zones) will assist the team in identifying their areas of mutual accountability.

Decision-making

Helping the team decide how to operate when making decisions involves a balance along two axes. The first is associated with who will ultimately make the call and the decision. Are you seeking 'advice' to help you decide, or is this something that needs to be a joint corporate decision?

In some cases, teams might choose, or be constitutionally established with a presumption towards, the advisory approach. See the following examples:

> *The members of the executive committee are essentially advisers, constitutionally, to the vice-chancellor, although I cannot think of an instance recently in which the vice-chancellor's gone against the strong feeling in the executive committee.*

> *It's a VC's advisory group, okay? So, it's not formally in the structure and so we try to avoid, 'the SMT has decreed' or anything like that, so we make it clear it's advisory to the HoU, and because, you know, we have a vast number of committees, and it's important that things are properly channelled through them.*

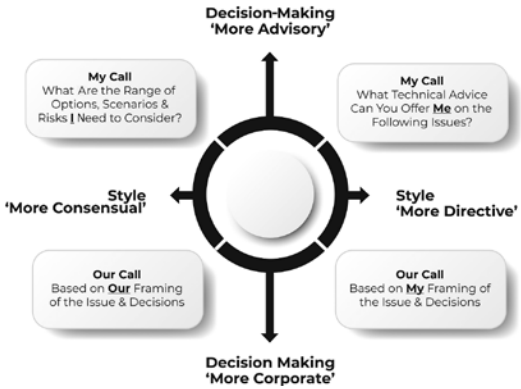

Figure 7.2 Four approaches to leadership style

How you get the balance right in these areas requires considering which leadership style is appropriate to the decision you are grappling with, from a more directive to a more consensual style. This involves choosing among four approaches, as shown in Figure 7.2. It also involves considering whether you are seeking advice from the team or you are seeking to achieve a collective decision. This creates four alternative combinations. All four have their place; your role as leader is to determine which is the most appropriate style, given the type of decision you are making and the context in which you are operating.

The how – values and behaviours

How the team should operate involves more balancing acts. Specifically, what values and behaviours should guide how you operate? Figure 7.3 combines five elements of high performance across both the *what* and the *how* of team working, emphasising a collective focus on modelling shared team values and behaviours.

Being clear about values and ways of working was emphasised by one of our interviewees:

> *I never took the time to make explicit to my team, how I'm going to work with them. I didn't take the time, and I've allowed probably 6 months to pass and it was only on Monday, when we had our first away day, that I took an hour and said this is my hour, I'm going to explain to you how I think, how I feel, how I want to work with you. I recognised that I probably should have been more explicit about this earlier, but I didn't take or make the opportunity to do that. This is now it. I've just come back from holiday with plenty of time to think*

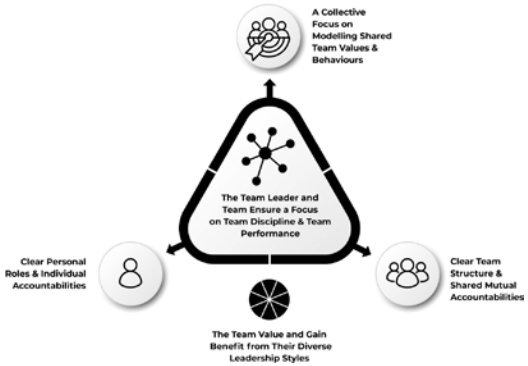

Figure 7.3 Five elements of high performance

> *about it. And it's not laying down the law what it is about. It is about ultimately, you know, you have to share my values and as long as that is the case, I can trust you and we will work together. I'm there to support you . . . but if you do not share my values, or yours are very different, then there will have to be a debate and yes, my values are not up for debate. Somebody said to me the other day, you are annoyed because people can't read your mind, and that was probably the case.*

In other cases, the HoU might encourage a conversation about the behaviours that would demonstrate the existence of a high-performing team, perhaps building on any university values that may already exist. This exercise could lead to the development of a set of principles or some form of 'team charter'. Table 7.1 is an example 'charter' developed by one senior leadership team.

A further area of focus involves recognising the value of a diversity in leadership styles exhibited by different team members. This is about acknowledging strengths and identifying gaps or areas that are less well represented. This is often helpfully informed by some form of team profiling. Whether and how much you invest in team profiling will depend on your context.

If you have inherited a team that you have judged, from a variety of sources, to be significantly lacking in specific areas or dysfunctional, you may be inclined towards drastic and quick action. One of our interviewees said the following on this topic:

> *Apart from my deputy, I basically asked everyone to just step down from their roles. They were open to reapply. I appointed only one of those to the new team.*

Table 7.1 A draft team charter: our principles and ways of operating as a senior leadership team

Theme	*Principles and Ways of Working*
Personal and interpersonal communications	• We actively listen to each other – seeking first to understand others' contributions and then to be understood. • We work to ensure a balance of contributions by all who wish to speak, avoiding overdominance by some or lack of opportunity to engage for others. • Our language and body language are constructive and supportive.
Solution seeking	• We adopt an action/outcome orientation to our work. • We aim to constructively build on the ideas of others. • We adopt a mindset which seeks to find innovative solutions to complex issues. • We look at issues from the perspective of what is best for the university.
Being adaptive	• We adapt our approach and decisions in the light of new data/changing circumstances. • We work towards the creation of win-win outcomes. • We think and act beyond the moment by seeing issues in a wider context.
Respect and relationships	• Our approach when debating matters will focus on the situation, issue or behaviour, not the person. • We aim to maintain the self confidence and self-esteem of others. • When differences arise, we will strive to ensure constructive relations are maintained.
Team ethos	• We will act in a way that creates an atmosphere where everyone feels able to say what they think. • In our decision-making, we will aim to balance overall interests, recognising that this may not, on every occasion, meet everyone's original positions. This approach is respected. • We will demonstrate through our actions 'cabinet responsibility' for outcomes & decisions.

In other circumstances (and also influenced by your style), you might take a different approach:

> *I believe everybody's got something to give and I really found it almost distasteful that a new vice-chancellor would come in and wipe out the existing team, and I felt that was disrespectful at some level. Of course, it does happen, I mean in my case, I'm now on my third reincarnation of a senior team and obviously sometimes, it's been people who have been helped to move along. As long as it has been people moving out of their own choice.*

> *It's about style, you know, if someone came in and said right, I'm getting rid of all the leaders, you can apply, as some people do you know, you can all apply for your own jobs again, and that's just not my style. I came in and I thought, well I'll give you a chance. Now I've changed all of my team, but I like to give, you know, find a way to give people a chance.*

A dilemma that can then arise in the building or rebuilding phase is who to appoint to the new vacancies. You may wish to build a team from people with whom you have worked in the past (or whom you have met through other sources, such as the Top Management Programme [TMP]). An interviewee offered a word of caution in such cases:

> *It's very odd when you move to a new place, you sort of inherit the team. You are a bit stuck with it. And I think you probably are actually, but there are some people who will come in and just say right. . . . I mean it's almost like a US president. New president comes in and you bring your team in. I've seen people do that, and they've brought people with them from previous places and it's been a complete disaster. Particularly with things like registrars or chief operating officers. Somebody says, well I worked with X there, I want to bring them in here. And they may have been really good in that context, but in this context, it doesn't work.*

This does not suggest that such appointments universally fail; many are highly successful. The important point is to be clear about your motive(s) for such an approach and to have a clearheaded view of your context and fit of the person to that context. You also need to assess the capacity of the person to operate as one of your line reports and, importantly, assess the impact of your earlier relationship on the rest of the team. Above all, encourage good people to apply to join you, but as much for their credibility as your own, ensure their appointment is achieved through genuine competition against others in an open selection process. Avoid 'shoe-in by invitation' appointments.

As HoU, you will, of course, need to pay attention to methods of holding the team to account for team discipline and performance. When some lack of team discipline becomes apparent and this leads to conflict, two common, less helpful responses can arise. The first is for the leader to too early close down debate about significant differences of opinion. This may stem from a preference for conflict avoidance or a personal desire to impose a solution. Both lead to suboptimal outcomes, and thus the team fails openly to resolve issues. The differences remain, cliques start to form and increasingly more-political behaviours start to dominate. The second response is when the leader does not intervene to help resolve significant differences of opinion as expressed by team members. Such a laissez-faire approach can also be damaging. With little or no intervention, the parties may begin to adopt more-entrenched positions and express views even more strongly. As one interviewee expressed it,

> *The VC seemed to enjoy the Darwinian struggle which played out during almost every meeting between the same people.*

Whether such an outcome was through enjoyment or simply a lack of willingness or capacity to intervene effectively, the impact on the working of the top team was significant. In these circumstances, a more constructive approach is for the HoU to describe the behaviours that they are observing and the impact that such behaviours are having on team performance. Noting and naming the 'elephant in the room' is a start to the process of resolving this issue. Avoiding doing so simply exacerbates the situation and will, over time, diminish the influence of the HoU, in the eyes of the team.

In the forming stage of developing the teams, the HoU needs to role model this aspect of team working. In high-performing teams, as the team matures, all members of the team start to play their part. In doing so, they ensure that the team is living according to the ways of working (such as those set out earlier) that they have signed up to and that they wish to exemplify.

One interesting myth about team working is the extent to which 'being a team' is always necessary and required. In Katzenbach's work on teams at the top[8] in the corporate sector, he concludes as follows:

> *For much of the work it does (it may be as much as 70–80%) top teams don't operate as a real team. They are very effective single leader working groups. What matters, however, is that for that 20*[%]*–30% of their work where team discipline is critical, they always apply a team discipline.*

This, of course, raises the question of what constitutes the 20%–30% of issues for which a senior team must operate with team discipline. Determining these will help reinforce the matter of mutual accountability and also help clarify the areas of team performance to which you need to pay particular attention as HoU.

If the different dimensions of top-team working as outlined so far resonate, and you are ready and willing to invest time and energy into team development, then this may become an area of significant focus for you in your role. As one interviewee commented,

> *I've put most of my effort into team building and team management and that's really where I've focused all of my effort. You need to referee the fights, you need to agree and really work together, and maximise what you can do together, and then have the similar messages that are transmitted in ways that can't be used against you.*

Extradependent teams

An interesting concept developed by David Kesby adds to the literature on teams.[9] He argues that in addition to the classic *interdependent team* with mutual accountability (as described by Katzenbach and Smith earlier) is another complementary form of teamwork, the *extradependent team*. Kesby contrasts the two models in Table 7.2.

How might this apply to a senior leadership team at a university? How might the team spend time improving learning about areas of common practice, complementing a more interdependent focus on individual and collective progress towards an agreed set of goals? Using the extradependent team approach, time could be spent on exploring issues where learning is required to achieve common practice by sharing individual contributions. In this approach, the team might, to take a few examples, approach the process as follows (see Table 7.3):

An interdependent team approach and an extradependent team approach are both needed at different times and in different ways. We know of one new HoU in

Table 7.2 Two models of teams

Interdependent teams	*Extradependent teams*
Depend on people *inside* the team	Depend on people *outside* the team
Different skills	*Similar* skills
Common *goal*	Common *practice*
Mutual accountability	*Individual* accountability
Improve through *working together better*	Improve through *learning better together*

Table 7.3 Examples of the extradependent approach

Illustrative top-team theme	*Common practice*	*Potential questions to improve through learning*
Governance	To build a consistent and coordinated process, to inform shared decision-making with the governing body.	• How do each of us currently provide our board with relevant data and insights to guide shared decision-making? • What do they think of our approach? • What could we do more of or less of to enhance our common practice?
Blended/hybrid student experience	To share the experience of delivery by many staff, to create a high-quality and diverse learning experience which adapts to evolving needs.	• What is each of us contributing to and learning about our journey towards this shared ambition? • What are the incentives and barriers to our shared common practice? • What does this help us learn about delivering innovation?
Student welfare and support	To ensure that we share data and insights so that we take actions to address issues and concerns raised by students	• What insights are we able to offer, on the basis of experience in each of our portfolios? • What can we learn at the moment from our individual areas to help us focus on the collective issues of highest priority to students?
Research	. . .	. . .
Enterprise	. . .	. . .

a UK university who has chosen a learning process like this to build and develop the senior team at that university.

One final point for reflection for you as an HoU is what you reward (formally and informally) and how this relates to the performance of your top team. Formally, you may have inherited a system of performance-related pay (PRP). If such a system exists, you might also wish to understand the balance between rewards given for personal performance and the proportion (if any) that recognises team performance. Depending on your commitment to team performance and its improvement, you could consider whether a greater proportion of the reward (if not all) should be based on team performance. It's a simple but symbolically significant indicator to the team of what matters. In our experience, typical university reward structures tend towards personal rather than team performance.

Top-team dilemmas

On the basis of discussions and work with many top teams, a number of common dilemmas can arise for a new leader in relation to their team. Three of the more common dilemmas involve the size of the top team, the role of a deputy (and whom should deputise for you when you are absent) and timing – when is the optimal time to change the membership of your team?

The team-size dilemma

Team size often comes first:

- Do I create a large inclusive team? If so, how large should it be?
- Do I have an inner team within a broader body?
- Do I create a single small 'top team'?

The arguments on both sides are persuasive. See Table 7.4 for examples.

Given these conditions, what are your options? Here are four alternatives:

1. Create a formal inner team within the bigger team model – with a focus for the former on strategic issues.
2. Create a formal team within the larger team model – where the former is focused primarily on operational issues (e.g. the Monday morning meeting).
3. Create an informal team which acts as a 'triage system' – to refine the agenda for the larger team and ensure that the right issues are brought to the larger team.
4. Create a 'hybrid' informal team that operates along clear lines of authority from the larger team to both set the agenda for the main meetings and implement some decisions within agreed limits.

Table 7.4 Example arguments for top-team size

Arguments for a large team	*Arguments against too large a team*
Be inclusive and involve everyone, being a leader who ensures that all key voices are heard.	A large team's dynamics can make hearing all voices difficult to achieve, in practice.
Collective agenda setting builds ownership.	Collective agenda setting can sometimes lead to too much 'upward delegation' – feeling the need to get team endorsement for areas of individual accountability.
Benefits accrue in decision-making from having a wide and diverse range of views and mindsets.	Too much diversity of opinion and approach can ultimately make consensual decision-making difficult to achieve.
By engaging others in decisions, you in theory have a higher likelihood of decisions' being executed.	As a consequence of the preceding point, the likelihood of decision-making's having to be top-down increases – with an associated danger of a lack of commitment to delivering outcomes.
By involving a range of senior leaders, you can cascade key messages and decisions quickly, across the university.	For complex, cross-university decisions that may be contentious, careful communication is required, and this is best done by a smaller group of people.

Each of the foregoing points has its merits, the choice of which will be more appropriate depending on a range of factors:

- *The size and complexity of the institution* – all institutions are complex, but as scale increases, the size of the team also tends to grow, such that you might need to review and limit the team size. For example, both Monash and RMIT, which have more than 70,000 students enrolled, have top teams of eight and ten respectively.
- *The nature of your agenda* – the more sensitive the challenges you inherit are, the more common it is to initially create a small, inner team.
- *Your knowledge of the institution, its operating model and the extent to which you have an experienced deputy or provost* – the more familiar you are with each element of the university, the more likely you are initially to work with a small inner team. On the other hand, when you have limited experience with the institution and its operating model, you might find starting with a more inclusive and wider team structure useful.
- *Your team and its experience of working together* – whether you have inherited a relatively stable and high-performing team (if so, don't destabilise it too much) or whether you have inherited a team with many relative

newcomers and vacancies (in which case, you might wish to experiment with new approaches).

- *The history, traditions and culture of the place* – some battles may not be worth fighting, at least not initially.
- *Your working style* – you may have a preference for a particular way of operating, preferring to build a close relationship with a few trusted confidantes or to be inclusive and avoid too close a set of relationships with an inner group.

In the final analysis, you have to balance your preferences, team dynamics, context and culture.

The deputy/provost/COO/policy adviser/governance dilemmas

Another common dilemma is whether you should seek to appoint or retain a single person as your formal deputy and second in command or whether you see merit in having a series of deputies to whom you can delegate aspects of your agenda. How do you organise – and who leads – your professional services? Is this done through a single chief operating officer (COO)? Where does the finance function and chief finance officer sit? Do you have or wish to appoint a policy adviser? If so, to whom do they report? Are they formally a member of the team? Who coordinates and connects up the governance dots – particularly between you and the chair? These issues are complex, and a simple 'one size fits all' solution doesn't exist. Different factors come into play for each of these.

The deputy/provost dilemma

The variables in play depend on whether a formal deputy role exists or whether you are considering a new form for this role. Growth in use of the term *provost* – and differing interpretations of the role in the UK – were mentioned in Chapter 2.

If you are appointed from outside, the deputy/provost that you have inherited may well have been a contender for the top job. An early discussion to understand this person's ambitions will be useful. Their not being chosen for that role may have involved timing, so retaining this individual in role for a period of time, supporting their ambitions and offering them the opportunity to apply for roles could give you a valuable resource and time to think about what you need when appointing into this role. Of course, this assumes that you judge the individual to be highly competent and someone with whom you can work effectively.

In other cases, you may wish, in your early days in office, to dive into details and obtain a deep understanding of how your new institution operates. This may prove valuable later, although, particularly if you have previously been a deputy or provost, you might be at risk of being perceived to have remained in your comfort zone and are not stepping up into your new strategic role.

The decision to have one or multiple deputy roles is a further dilemma. Both models can work. For some, a single-deputy model can prove challenging, as one of our interviewees reflected:

> *I would say that is one of my failings, that I've never actually managed to appoint a deputy vice-chancellor that's worked for me. I've had a stop start progress in terms of appointing into that role and I think that has really been a disadvantage for me personally, not to have a good deputy vice-chancellor. But also, reflecting on appointments I've made around the top table and how to get that right, that's been one of the hardest things for me.*

For others, the multiple-deputies model – each having a distinct portfolio but also deputising for the HoU when requested – can prove useful. The choice is influenced by factors such as a desire to recognise multiple portfolios as being equally important, personal style (to reduce the number of direct reports) and the culture and constitution of the university. In some places, the concept of multiple DVCs (say) would not be culturally or constitutionally possible. In other cases, you might believe that you need to award the title of deputy to recruit or retain a key member of the team. Beware this flashpoint: you might find yourself in danger of 'promoting' one or more individuals who are not yet ready or deserving of the elevation. There is much to think about here.

The COO and finance director dilemma

Growth in the provost role on the academic side has been paralleled by growth in the appointment of chief operating officers (COO). This single term can encompass a range of portfolios. At one end is the all-embracing head of professional services; at the other is the more technically or commercially focused COO, who has oversight of a subset of professional disciplines. Strong views are held for both approaches. Supporters of the former emphasise the need for overarching coordination in all professional service areas, while the other perspective highlights the danger of too large a span of control and the need for specialist expertise at the top level, depending on the size and strategic agenda facing the university.

Further dilemmas exist in the relationship between and parity of esteem between the deputy/provost and COO roles and their scope and management reporting lines – for example, to the finance director (FD). Should you have the FD as chief finance officer (CFO) reporting directly to you or *through* the COO? Proponents of the former approach emphasise the need for the FD/CFO to be able to take an independent perspective on all aspects of expenditure rather than being responsible for large capital or investment decisions. By reporting directly to the HoU, they can provide unfiltered strategic advice. The alternative view, particularly where the COO has a more unitary and overarching role, highlights the importance of the FD's/CFO's being able to look across all areas of resource allocation and capital expenditure.

How they work (or do not work) collectively is just as important as the configuration of individual roles. In some instances, the trio (VC/provost/COO) or quad (with the addition of the independent FD/CFO) might become part of the senior team structure. In other instances, working processes are intentionally kept informal, to avoid adding another layer as an inner team, and avoiding the impression that all key decisions are made by an inner group.

The policy adviser dilemma

Policy adviser roles have also increased in recent times. As with the other roles, the title can encompass various responsibilities. The role may be positioned as senior adviser to the VC, as a chief of staff role coordinating the Vice-chancellor's Office or as a more technical role scanning policy horizons and acting as an interface with external bodies. As a new HoU, you might either inherit a well-functioning office that is fulfilling analysis, policy scanning and advisory roles or consider whether and how you can create such a suite of capabilities. To understand the functions, the different configurations and the value that can be added by policy advisers, you may find value in the work of Bagshaw and McVitty[10] and the work – in the UK – of the Lighthouse Policy Group.[11]

The governance dilemma

The final, and possibly most demanding of the dilemmas that you may face, is how to build connections between members of your senior team and members of your governing board/council/court. How do you draw on the wisdom and experience of your board while keeping a clear line between governance and executive leadership? Some universities in the UK have attempted to achieve this through a formalised 'dual assurance' model, where board members are formally linked with members of the senior team. Others take a more informal approach, by encouraging board members to contribute to those areas where they feel they can offer ideas and insights. Keep a watchful eye on this domain, to ensure that you are either giving it the attention it deserves or being careful to avoid its becoming an area that demands too much of your time and attention.

Conclusions

Creating, developing and leading your top team is a significant point of transition for you as HoU (and, indeed, will likely involve more than one transition as the team changes over time). The task involves many skills that you will have developed in earlier phases of your career, but it will also demand new capabilities. Above all, it will require the capacity to achieve the right balance across individuals' competence, experience and personalities and your context and your requirements. Striking the right balance will help you to build a high-performing team

and enable you to accelerate the development of a shared strategy and capacity to deliver your strategic and operational priorities.

Notes

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3 T. Kennie and S. Woodfield (2008). *The Composition, Challenges and Changes in the Top Team Structures of UK Higher Education Institutions*. London, Development Report, the Leadership Foundation for Higher Education, p. 73.
4 Kennie and Woodfield, op cit.
5 J. Katzenbach and D.G. Smith (2003). *The Wisdom of Teams*. New York, Collins.
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7 J. Hildreth and C. Anderson (2016). Failure at the Top: How Power Undermines Collaborative Performance. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, American Psychological Association*, vol. 110, no. 2, pp. 261–286. IRLE Working Paper, #122-14.
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9 D. Kesby (2019). *Extra-Dependent Teams*. London, Routledge.
10 A. Bagshaw and D. McVitty (eds.) (2019). *Influencing Higher Education Policy*. London, Routledge, p. 179.
11 Lighthouse Policy Group. www.lighthousepolicygroup.net/ (accessed September 3, 2020).